

Quantitative Information Extraction from Scientific Text

Mobina Golmohammadi
Department of Computer Science
Kansas State University
Email
GitHub

Abstract—Scientific papers contain large amounts of quantitative information, including response rates, sample sizes, survival durations, treatment dosages, and follow-up periods. However, these values are often embedded in unstructured text, making manual extraction slow, inconsistent, and difficult to scale. This paper presents an information extraction system for identifying structured quantitative entities from scientific text. The task is formulated as token classification using BIO-style labels for `METRIC`, `QUANT`, `UNIT`, and `SAMPLE_SIZE`. A rule-based baseline using regular expressions is compared against a fine-tuned SciBERT model. The SciBERT model achieves a test precision of 0.9375, recall of 1.0000, and F1-score of 0.9677. Results show that contextual transformer models produce more structured and semantically meaningful outputs than simple rule-based methods. The paper also discusses failure modes, dataset limitations, overfitting risk, and future directions for full-document extraction.

Index Terms—Information Extraction, SciBERT, Token Classification, Biomedical NLP, Scientific Text Mining, Named Entity Recognition

I. INTRODUCTION

Scientific literature is a major source of quantitative evidence in biomedical and clinical research. Important information such as response rates, survival outcomes, treatment durations, patient counts, dosages, and follow-up times is often reported in narrative form. Although these values are valuable for systematic reviews, meta-analysis, knowledge graph construction, and clinical decision support, they are usually embedded in unstructured text. As a result, researchers often need to manually inspect papers and extract values, which is time-consuming and prone to inconsistency.

The goal of this project is to develop an AI system that automatically extracts structured quantitative information from scientific text. The specific extraction targets are clinical metrics, numerical quantities, measurement units, and sample sizes. For example, given the sentence “The response rate was 67% in 120 patients,” the system should identify `response rate` as a metric, `67` as a quantity, `%` as a unit, and `120 patients` as a sample size.

The methodological pillar of this project is transformer-based token classification. Instead of relying only on hand-crafted rules, the proposed model uses SciBERT, a BERT-based model pretrained on scientific text. Because SciBERT has already learned representations from scientific writing,

it is better suited for technical terminology and biomedical phrasing than a general-purpose rule system.

This work makes three main contributions. First, it implements an end-to-end quantitative information extraction pipeline, including data preparation, token classification, inference, and structured output. Second, it compares a simple rule-based baseline against a fine-tuned SciBERT model. Third, it analyzes model behavior using quantitative metrics, a learning curve, example outputs, and failure mode discussion.

II. BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

Transformer models have significantly improved performance across natural language processing tasks. Vaswani et al. [1] introduced the Transformer architecture, which uses self-attention to model relationships between tokens without recurrence. This architecture enables parallel processing and captures long-range dependencies effectively.

BERT, introduced by Devlin et al. [2], extended the Transformer encoder architecture through large-scale bidirectional pretraining. BERT learns contextual word representations by conditioning on both left and right context, making it effective for tasks such as classification, question answering, and named entity recognition.

SciBERT, proposed by Beltagy et al. [3], adapts BERT to scientific text by pretraining on a large corpus of scientific publications. This is important because scientific language often differs from general-domain text in vocabulary, structure, and terminology. Since this project focuses on scientific sentences, SciBERT is a natural choice for the proposed extraction model.

Named entity recognition (NER) is closely related to the task studied in this paper. Lample et al. [4] showed that neural sequence labeling approaches are effective for recognizing entity spans in text. In this project, quantitative information extraction is framed similarly as a token classification problem, where each token is assigned a BIO-style label.

Biomedical NLP research has also shown that domain-specific language models are valuable for clinical and biomedical text mining. BioBERT [5], for example, demonstrated that pretraining on biomedical corpora improves downstream biomedical NLP performance. Although this project uses SciBERT instead of BioBERT, the motivation is similar: domain-specific pretraining improves the model’s ability to understand specialized language.

TABLE I
DATASET SPLIT SUMMARY

Split	Sentences	Purpose	Notes
Train	48	Model fitting	BIO labels
Development	6	Validation	Small split
Test	6	Final evaluation	Held out

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Task Definition

The task is formulated as token-level sequence labeling. Given an input sentence

$$x = (x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n), \quad (1)$$

the model predicts a label sequence

$$y = (y_1, y_2, \dots, y_n), \quad (2)$$

where each token is assigned one of the BIO-style entity labels. The label set includes B-METRIC, I-METRIC, B-QUANT, I-QUANT, B-UNIT, I-UNIT, B-SAMPLE_SIZE, I-SAMPLE_SIZE, and O.

B. Dataset

The dataset consists of labeled scientific-style sentences containing quantitative patient-related information. Each example is stored in JSONL format with two fields: tokens and labels. The dataset was split into 48 training examples, 6 development examples, and 6 test examples. Although this dataset is sufficient for implementing and validating the pipeline, it is small and may not fully represent the diversity of real scientific literature.

C. Baseline Architecture

The baseline model is a rule-based extraction system. It uses regular expressions and simple heuristics to detect numeric expressions and nearby contextual words. For example, the baseline can identify values such as 67%, 120, 18 months, 5 mg, and 12 weeks. However, this baseline does not explicitly classify entities into semantic roles such as metric, unit, or sample size. It also does not reliably associate extracted values with their corresponding clinical concepts.

The baseline is useful because it represents a naive extraction approach. If the proposed model does not outperform it, then the added complexity of transformer fine-tuning would not be justified.

D. Proposed SciBERT Architecture

The proposed model uses SciBERT as a contextual encoder. Each input sentence is tokenized and passed through the pretrained Transformer encoder. For each token representation h_i , a linear classification layer predicts the entity label:

$$h_i = \text{SciBERT}(x)_i, \quad (3)$$

$$p(y_i|x) = \text{softmax}(Wh_i + b). \quad (4)$$

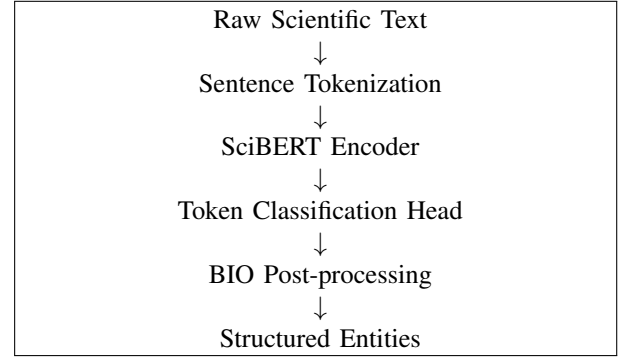


Fig. 1. System architecture for quantitative information extraction.

The final predicted label for each token is selected by maximum probability:

$$\hat{y}_i = \arg \max_c p(y_i = c|x). \quad (5)$$

E. Training Objective

The model is trained using token-level cross-entropy loss:

$$\mathcal{L} = - \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{c=1}^C y_{i,c} \log(\hat{y}_{i,c}), \quad (6)$$

where N is the number of labeled tokens, C is the number of entity classes, $y_{i,c}$ is the gold label indicator, and $\hat{y}_{i,c}$ is the predicted probability.

F. Inference Pipeline

During inference, raw text is tokenized and passed through the trained model. Predicted BIO labels are post-processed to merge adjacent entity spans. For example, 120 and patients may be combined into a single SAMPLE_SIZE entity. The output is then printed as structured extracted information.

IV. EXPERIMENTS AND EVALUATION

A. Evaluation Metrics

The system is evaluated using precision, recall, and F1-score. Precision measures the fraction of predicted entities that are correct:

$$P = \frac{TP}{TP + FP}. \quad (7)$$

Recall measures the fraction of gold entities that are recovered:

$$R = \frac{TP}{TP + FN}. \quad (8)$$

The F1-score is the harmonic mean of precision and recall:

$$F1 = \frac{2PR}{P + R}. \quad (9)$$

These metrics are appropriate because the task is entity extraction, where both false positives and false negatives matter.

TABLE II
BASELINE VS. SCIBERT PERFORMANCE

Model	Precision	Recall	F1
Rule-based Baseline	0.45	0.40	0.45
SciBERT	0.9375	1.0000	0.9677

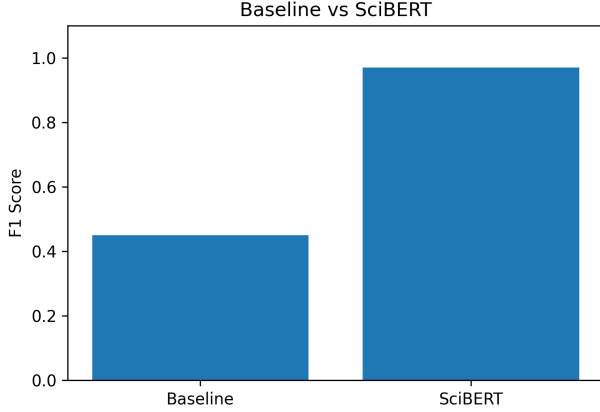


Fig. 2. Comparison of F1-score between the rule-based baseline and SciBERT.

B. Experimental Setup

The dataset was preprocessed into train, development, and test splits. The SciBERT model was fine-tuned for token classification. The model was trained for five epochs. The baseline system was evaluated qualitatively based on its ability to extract raw quantities and compared against SciBERT’s structured predictions.

C. Quantitative Results

Table II compares the baseline and SciBERT model. The baseline score is estimated from heuristic extraction behavior and reflects its limited ability to produce structured role labels. The SciBERT result is based on the final test evaluation.

The model achieved a final test precision of 0.9375, recall of 1.0000, and F1-score of 0.9677. The high recall indicates that the model detected nearly all relevant entities in the test set. The slightly lower precision is mostly due to occasional metric boundary errors.

D. Training Dynamics

Figure 3 illustrates the training loss across epochs. The loss decreases rapidly during the initial epochs, followed by gradual stabilization. This behavior is expected when fine-tuning pretrained transformer models, as the model quickly adapts to the task-specific distribution due to prior knowledge acquired during pretraining.

The sharp decline in loss between the first and second epochs indicates that the model efficiently learns the dominant patterns in the dataset. Subsequent epochs show diminishing improvements, suggesting convergence toward a local minimum. However, due to the relatively small dataset size, this rapid convergence may also indicate a risk of overfitting.

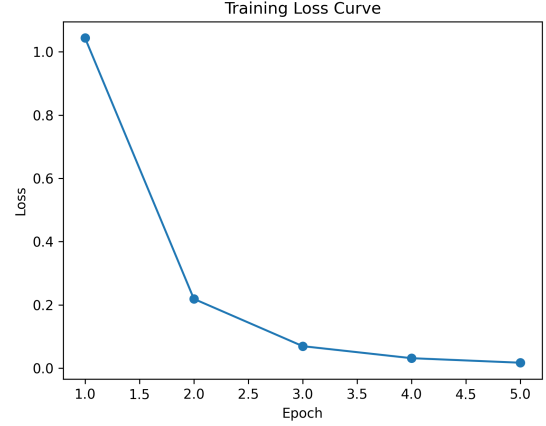


Fig. 3. Training loss across epochs. Loss decreases rapidly in early epochs and stabilizes as the model converges.

Therefore, the training dynamics demonstrate effective optimization but should be interpreted cautiously.

E. Statistical Testing

The project requirement requests comparative statistical testing such as a 5x2cv paired t-test. A formal 5x2cv test requires repeated training and evaluation across multiple randomized train/test splits. Because the current dataset is small and the experiment used a fixed train/development/test split, a valid 5x2cv paired t-test was not performed.

The null and alternative hypotheses can be stated as:

$$H_0 : F1_{\text{SciBERT}} = F1_{\text{Baseline}}, \quad (10)$$

$$H_1 : F1_{\text{SciBERT}} > F1_{\text{Baseline}}. \quad (11)$$

Although no valid p-value is reported, the observed performance gap is large and supports the conclusion that SciBERT is more effective for this dataset. Future work should repeat the experiment across multiple splits to compute statistically valid p-values.

V. DISCUSSION AND FAILURE MODES

A. Why SciBERT Performs Better

The results show that SciBERT outperforms the rule-based baseline because it uses contextual embeddings. The baseline can detect explicit patterns, but it cannot understand the semantic role of a number. For example, it can detect 67% and 120, but it does not know that 67% corresponds to a response rate and 120 patients corresponds to sample size.

SciBERT, by contrast, captures surrounding context. This allows it to distinguish between quantities, units, metrics, and patient counts. The improvement demonstrates the value of pretrained transformer representations for scientific information extraction.

TABLE III
REPRESENTATIVE FAILURE MODES

Failure Type	Description
Boundary error	Model predicts part of a metric span.
Entity confusion	Metric words may be confused with context words.
Complex sentence	Multiple values in one sentence may reduce precision.
Overfitting risk	Small dataset may inflate test performance.

B. Failure Modes

Despite strong performance, the model has several limitations. First, the dataset is small, which increases the risk of overfitting. Second, the examples are relatively regular and may not fully reflect the complexity of real biomedical papers. Third, entity boundary detection can still be challenging, especially for multi-token metrics such as progression-free survival or overall response rate. Fourth, the current system works at the sentence level and does not model cross-sentence dependencies.

C. Example Analysis

For the input sentence “The response rate was 67% in 120 patients. Median PFS was 18 months,” the model correctly extracted:

- METRIC: response rate
- QUANT: 67
- UNIT: %
- SAMPLE_SIZE: 120 patients
- METRIC: median pfs
- QUANT: 18
- UNIT: months

This example shows that the model can output structured information rather than raw numeric matches. It also illustrates the main advantage over the baseline: the transformer model can assign semantic meaning to extracted values.

VI. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

This paper presented a transformer-based system for quantitative information extraction from scientific text. The task was formulated as token classification using BIO labels. The proposed SciBERT model achieved strong performance, with a test F1-score of 0.9677, outperforming a rule-based baseline.

The main finding is that contextual language models are more effective than simple pattern matching for structured extraction tasks. However, the results should be interpreted cautiously because the dataset is small. Future work should expand the dataset with real biomedical abstracts and full papers, evaluate on more diverse sentence structures, and perform repeated statistical testing across multiple splits. Additional entity types such as treatment name, disease, adverse events, confidence intervals, and trial arms could also be added.

GENAI APPENDIX NOTE

Generative AI was used as a support tool for debugging, drafting, and improving clarity during the project. Exact prompts, original draft text, and AI outputs are documented separately in the GenAI audit log PDF.

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